

Richard Anaya

HEAD OF ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE · TECHNICAL LEADER & BUILDER

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Professional Summary

I'm an AI leader who still ships code. As Head of AI at Formant, I lead a team of 5-7, shape AI strategy with executive leadership, and write production TypeScript nearly every day building RAG and agent systems for robotics. Over 18 years across startups and large companies — Magic Leap, Evernote, Charles Schwab — I've built everything from real-time data pipelines, 3D robotics visualization, to exotic virtual reality teleoperation. What I do best is align technology and business: figuring out what's worth building and how to build it, then making it happen.

Professional Experience

Formant

Head of Artificial Intelligence

January 2025 – Present · Portland, OR

- Lead a team of 5-7 engineers, integrating contributors' work, shaping the team's roadmap with product management, and keeping the company informed through all-hands status updates.
- Launched 3 major AI prototypes — work begun before stepping into the Head of AI role — that have driven the product direction for 2 years; two reached customers and now influence how they run day-to-day robotics operations.
- Partnered with executive leadership and product management to shape AI strategy and roadmap, translating emerging RAG and foundation model capabilities into prioritized initiatives with clear business impact.
- Built many of the earliest AI prototypes, establishing core technical patterns and de-risking key product directions through rapid, hands-on development.
- Wrote and shipped production code on a near-daily basis in TypeScript (Mastra, Vercel AI SDK, and modern RAG tooling), while ensuring clean integration across multiple contributors' work.
- Conducted research on models and approaches while actively aligning direction with customer needs through conversations with FDEs, sales, and leadership — ensuring technical investments had the highest probability of delivering real business results.
- Aligned team skills and priorities to build sustained execution momentum, helping engineers focus on high-leverage problems with clarity under ambiguity.
- Educated leadership and cross-functional stakeholders on realistic AI opportunities, tradeoffs, and integration considerations, improving organizational decision quality.

Staff Software Engineer

June 2020 – January 2025 · Portland, OR

- Built an advanced data ingestion pipeline on AWS (PostgreSQL, Kafka, S3) for near-realtime telemetry storage and display.
- Developed telemetry collection agents in Go using Pion WebRTC for realtime transmission of telemetry data to frontend web experiences.
- Built Three.js and WebXR visualizations of advanced robotics data — transformation trees, URDFs, and complex environments — in the browser and on Meta Quest VR headsets.
- Created architectures and open-source libraries that enable customers to extend the platform and accelerate their own success in market.
- Served as a technical voice to leadership, presenting opportunities and complexity to guide strategic decisions.
- Worked directly with customers to understand needs and deliver solutions that create tangible value for custom robotics visualization modules.
- Led process improvements in collaboration with product to focus engineering effort on high-impact work.

Magic Leap

Senior Software / Data Engineer

October 2016 – June 2020 · Portland, OR

- Built the web platform for managing augmented reality app store submissions.
- Developed the React frontend and a serverless backend on AWS Lambda, DynamoDB, and S3.
- Enabled data scientists and business insights by writing large-scale data processing systems, automating cloud infrastructure using Databricks.

Evernote

Software Engineer

August 2012 – May 2014 · Austin, TX

Built JavaScript features for the Evernote Web client and the Skitch drawing app.

Charles Schwab

Software Engineer

September 2008 – January 2011 · Austin, TX

Developed UX and financial data visualization for Schwab's trading platform.

Technical Skills I Use Every Month

AI & Agent Systems

Mastra AI fal.ai MCP servers RAG architectures & patterns Model evaluation & cost optimization
Prompt engineering Generative AI prototyping

Languages & Frameworks

TypeScript JavaScript React Node.js React Three Fiber Three.js

Data, Infrastructure & Cloud

PostgreSQL Docker Daytona pipelines AWS Cloud automation

Visualization & Real-time

WebSockets Data visualization for robotics

Leadership & Process

Cross-functional technical leadership Team alignment & momentum building Product leadership collaboration
Open-source library development

Technical Skills I've Used Deeply Before

Languages, AI & Data

Python Go Rust WebAssembly Vercel AI SDK Snowflake

Infrastructure, Robotics & Real-time

Kafka Upstash queues WebRTC ROS 1/2 Google Cloud Platform Scalable data pipelines

Personal Projects

- **tourofrust.com** — international Rust education site; 900+ GitHub stars, community-translated into 18 languages
- Extensions for the **pi CLI** AI coding agent
- AI agent experiments focused on cross-agent communication, AI looping, memory systems
- Generative art projects using writing plots, video, image, and segmentation AI models for storytelling
- Cooking and food science

Education

Rice University — Bachelor of Arts, Computer Science (2001 – 2005)